

In Excel, **Date Functions** are used to handle information such as days, months, and years, allowing for automated calculations based on timeframes. Because Excel stores dates as serial numbers, these functions are necessary to extract specific parts of a date or calculate the difference between two points in time.

1. Core Extraction Functions

These functions allow you to pull specific components out of a full date.

- **DAY()**: Returns the day of the month (a number from 1 to 31) from a specific date.
 - **MONTH()**: Returns the month (a number from 1 to 12) from a specific date.
 - **YEAR()**: Returns the four-digit year from a specific date.
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2. Dynamic "Now" Functions

These functions are useful for creating reports that update automatically every time you open the file.

- **TODAY()**: Returns the current date according to your system settings.
 - **NOW()**: Returns the current date and the specific time.
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3. Date Construction and Calculation

- **DATE()**: Creates a valid Excel date by combining individual year, month, and day values.
 - *Syntax*: `=DATE(year, month, day)`.
 - **DATEDIF()**: Calculates the difference between two dates in years, months, or days. This is frequently used for calculating age or employee tenure.
 - **EDATE()**: Returns a date that is a specific number of months before or after a start date.
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4. Practical Applications

- **Simple Calculations**: You can perform basic math on dates, such as adding **+7** to a date to find the deadline exactly one week later.
- **Fill Series**: Excel can automatically extend a sequence of dates, months, or days of the week using the **Fill Series** tool.
- **Data Validation**: You can use **Data Validation** to restrict a cell so that users can only enter dates within a specific range, such as after the company's founding date.
- **Sorting and Filtering**: Once data is correctly recognized as a date type, you can easily sort it from oldest to newest or filter it to show only records from a specific month or year.

